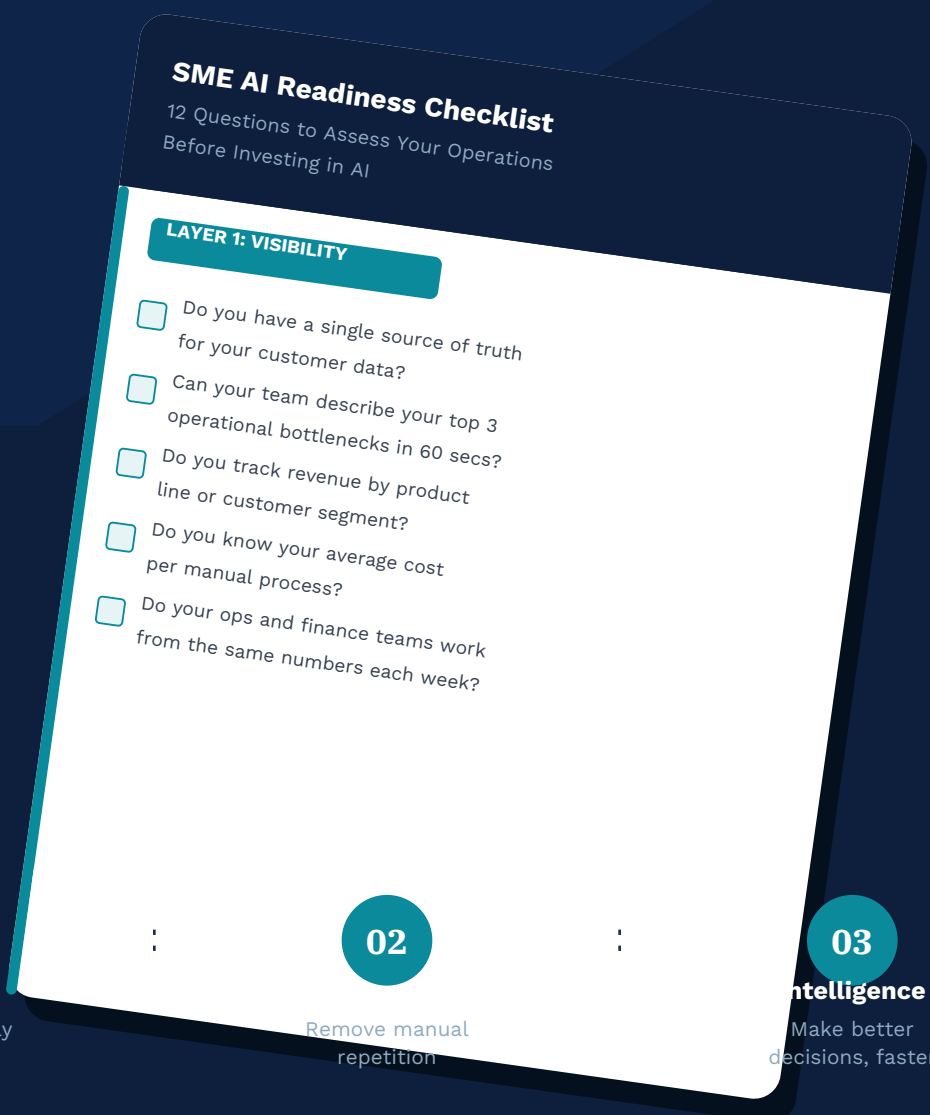


SME AI Readiness Checklist

12 Questions to Assess Your Operations
Before Investing in AI



01

Visibility

See what is really
happening

02

Remove manual
repetition

03

Intelligence

Make better
decisions, faster

Answer each question honestly. Score one point for YES. No partial credit. A solid NO is just as useful as a YES. It tells you exactly where to focus.

LAYER 1

Layer 1: Visibility

See clearly before you automate anything

Q01

Do you have a single source of truth for your customer data?☐

Why this matters: If sales, finance, and ops each have a different spreadsheet, AI cannot fix the split. It needs one version of the truth.

Q02

Can your team describe your top three operational bottlenecks in under 60 seconds?☐

Why this matters: Speed of answer reveals depth of understanding. If it takes a meeting to figure out where work slows down, the bottleneck is visibility itself.

Q03

Do you track revenue by product line, region, or customer segment?☐

Why this matters: Top-line revenue without segmentation hides where growth is real and where it is carried by one lucky contract.

Q04

Do your operations team and finance team work from the same numbers each week?☐

Why this matters: Two teams, one set of numbers. That is the baseline. Misaligned reporting creates delays and decisions made on bad data.

LAYER 2

Layer 2: Automation

Identify what costs you time and accuracy every single day

Q05

Do you know your average cost per manual process (invoicing, data entry, follow-ups)?☐

Why this matters: Time multiplied by wage multiplied by frequency. If you cannot calculate it, you cannot make a business case for replacing it.

Q06

Are there tasks your team performs the same way every single day without variation?☐

Why this matters: Consistency is the automation signal. Fixed patterns are what tools handle best. If every case is different, judgment is required first.

Q07

Could a new team member follow a written process for your five most repeated tasks?☐

Why this matters: If the process only lives in someone's head, it is not ready to automate. Documentation is not bureaucracy. It is the blueprint.

Q08

Do you currently use tools such as a CRM, ERP, or accounting software that could be better connected?☐

Why this matters: Most SMEs already own the tools they need. The gap is integration. Disconnected software is value waiting to be released.

LAYER 3

Layer 3: Intelligence

Prepare for decisions that previously required experience

Q09

Do you have at least 12 months of clean, structured historical data in one place?☐

Why this matters: Forecasting and pattern detection require history. Three months of data cannot tell you what demand looks like next quarter.

Q10

Do you know which customers are most likely to churn in the next 90 days?☐

Why this matters: If you have never built a churn model, the honest answer is no. That is fine. It tells you exactly what your first AI project should be.

Q11

Can you identify which expenses are trending in the wrong direction before month-end close?☐

Why this matters: Real-time cost visibility stops surprises. Businesses that only see their numbers after the month is over are always reacting.

Q12

Does your team trust data enough to make decisions from it without calling a verification meeting?☐

Why this matters: Technology is rarely the bottleneck. Trust is. If people second-guess every report, the root problem is data quality and process ownership.

Q13

Do you have one named person responsible for data quality in your business?☐

Why this matters: Without ownership, data degrades. It does not need to be a full-time hire. It needs to be someone whose name you can actually say.

Scoring Guide: What Your Total Means

Score 0 to 4

Start with Visibility

You need a clear picture before anything else. Consolidate your data into one place and build a dashboard your whole team checks each week. That is your entire job right now.

Score 5 to 8

Move to Automation

Your visibility is solid enough. Pick your three most time-consuming manual processes, document each one properly, then find the tool that eliminates them. That sequence matters.

Score 9 to 12

Ready for Intelligence

Your data is clean and routine processes run without you. Now apply AI to real decisions: forecasting, churn prediction, spend analysis. This is where the return becomes measurable.

Want to talk through your score?

Send your score and your top bottleneck and I will respond within 24 hours.

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